

Tensions Between Biomedical Ethics Review and Responsible AI Research at a University Hospital in South America

Sofia Martinelli^{1,2,3}, Luciana Benotti^{1,2,3}, Viviana Cotik^{3,5}, Lorena Etcheverry⁴

¹Universidad Nacional de Córdoba (Argentina), ²Fundación Vía Libre (Argentina), ³CONICET (Argentina), ⁴Instituto de Computación, Universidad de la República (Uruguay), ⁵Departamento de Computación, Universidad de Buenos Aires (Argentina)

Are traditional biomedical ethics review processes sufficient for exploratory Responsible AI research involving LLMs?

Motivation

The increasing use of Large Language Models (LLMs) in healthcare introduces technical and ethical risks that may not be fully captured by traditional biomedical ethics review.

Case Study

We examine the ethics review of an interdisciplinary Responsible AI project developed within CICADA (Udelar) in collaboration with the Hospital de Clínicas in Uruguay.

The project brings together computer science, medicine, and social sciences to investigate the responsible use of LLMs in healthcare.



Ethics review: two major tensions emerged

1 Methodological mismatch

Traditional review assumes stability; Responsible AI research is exploratory and iterative.

Biomedical ethics review

Stable

- Predefined protocols.
- Specified interventions.
- Risks identified in advance.

Responsible AI research

Iterative

- Adaptive workflows.
- Exploratory use cases.
- Risks discovered through experimentation.

2 Conceptual gap

Review focused on privacy and confidentiality, but key Responsible AI risks were not addressed.

Covered by review

- Privacy.
- Anonymization.
- Confidentiality.
- Consent & Data governance.

Additional risks

- Hallucinations.
- Algorithmic biases.
- Explainability.
- Uncertainty communication.
- Governance of model outputs.

